

Programming Language Popularity Rankings

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Python leads at

21.25%

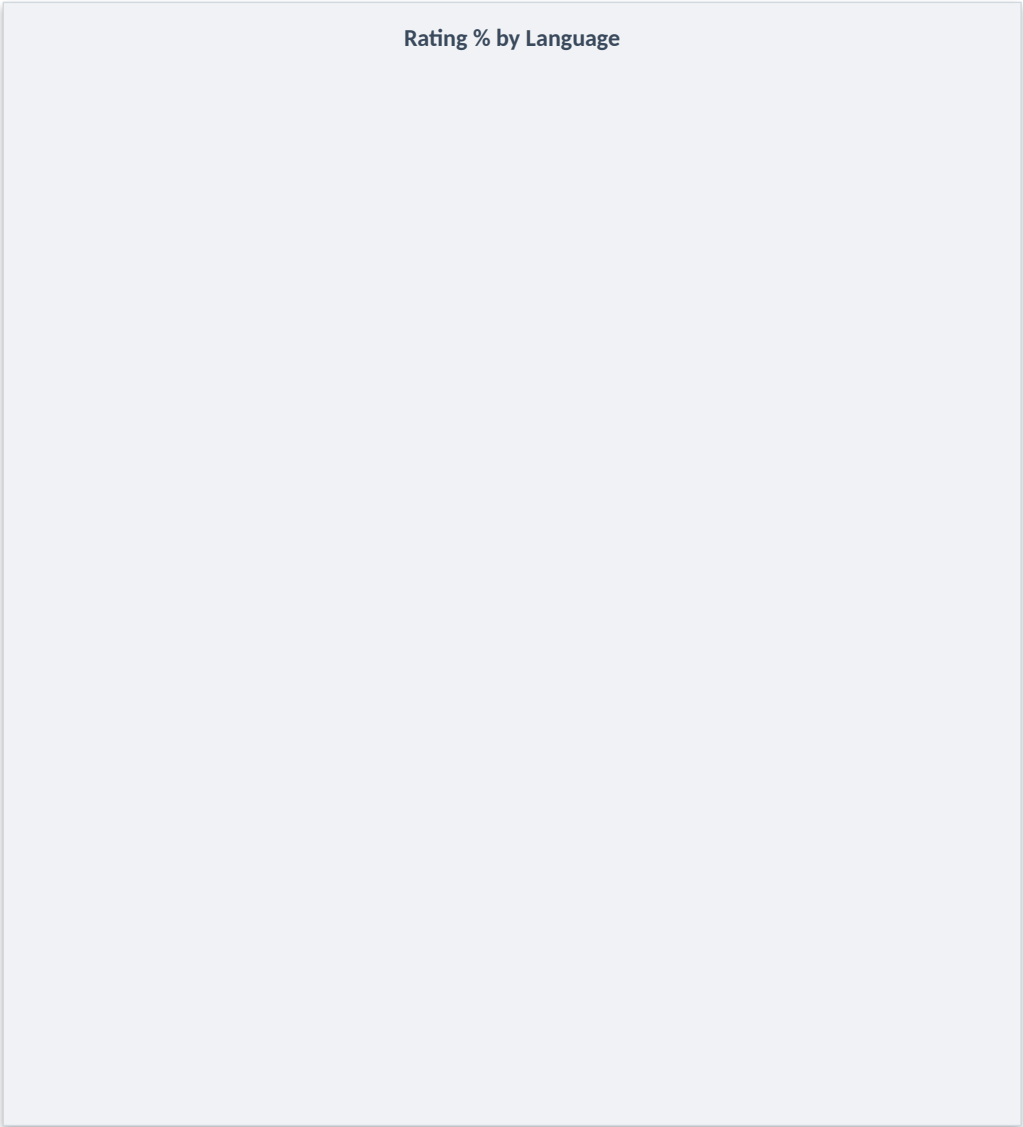
while C surges to #2 and Go drops
from 7th to 16th — a -9 rank fall.

Audience: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

Top 20 Programming Languages: Python at #1 but C Surges to #2

Full rankings with year-over-year change | March 2026 vs March 2025

2026 Rank	2025 Rank	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Year-over-year rank changes | March 2025 → March 2026

RISING

Perl	R	Swift	Assembly	C#
+13	+7	+6	+2	+0
24th → 11th	16th → 9th	26th → 20th	17th → 17th	5th → 5th

FALLING

Go	C++	Java	PHP	SQL
-9	-1	-1	-5	-2
7th → 16th	2nd → 3rd	3rd → 4th	13th → 18th	8th → 10th

KEY INSIGHT

Go's Fall from Grace

Go dropped from 7th to 16th, losing 1.49 percentage points — the largest absolute drop in the top 20. Once Language of the Year in 2016, it now faces competition from Rust in systems programming.

Perl's Renaissance

Perl's jump from 24th to 11th is the largest rank gain of any language this cycle (+13 positions). Driven by legacy infrastructure and automation workloads still relying on Perl's text-processing strength.

Swift Re-Enters, Kotlin Exits

Swift climbed from 26th to 20th at Kotlin's expense, reflecting Apple platform momentum versus cross-platform framework competition.

From Lisp #2 in 1986 to Python #1 in 2026: Four Decades of Language Shifts

Long-term rank history showing how Python rose from unranked to dominant

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

TREND: Top 4 Language Ratings 2002–2026 (schematic)

- Python
- C
- Java
- C++

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

TIOBE Programming Language of the Year award winners, 2016–2025

6

LANGUAGE OF
THE YEAR

WINS

PYTHON'S 6 WINS

2007

WIN

2010

WIN

2018

WIN

2020

WIN

2021

WIN

2024

WIN

More wins than any other language. C# has 2 wins (2023, 2025); C won once (2019); C++ won once (2022); Go won once (2016).

Year	Winner	Rank Change	Rating Gain
2025	C#	5th → 5th	+1.49%
2024	Python	1st → 1st	+1.18%
2023	C#	6th → 5th	+1.18%
2022	C++	4th → 3rd	+1.57%
2021	Python	3rd → 1st	+4.62%
2020	Python	3rd → 1st	+3.92%
2019	C	2nd → 2nd	+3.02%
2018	Python	4th → 1st	+6.41%
2016	Go	19th → 11th	+4.02%

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python's Dominance vs. Decline Trajectory

Python leads at 21.25% — more than 2× second-place C. But its -2.59% YoY decline is the steepest among the top 5. Teams invested in Python should monitor the trend; the language remains strong but its relative lead is shrinking.

C's Resurgence: Systems Programming Revival

C climbed to #2 with +2.02% gain — the largest positive move in the top 5. This aligns with growing interest in systems-level programming, embedded, and performance-critical workloads where C's efficiency is valued over modern conveniences.

Legacy Language Revival: Perl, Fortran, R

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7 ranks), and Fortran (holding top 15) show surprising resilience. These languages serve entrenched communities in scientific computing, data analysis, and infrastructure automation — not mere nostalgia.

Go's Sharp Fall: From Language of the Year to -9 Rank Drop

Go's drop from 7th to 16th (largest absolute decline: -1.49 pts) is the most dramatic fall in the index. Rust's steady climb (14th, +0.09%) may be absorbing systems-programming mindshare that Go once captured.

The top 4 languages (Python + C + C++ + Java) hold 48.97% of the total TIOBE index — concentration risk for single-language strategies